

Jared Lomeli

Professor Studer

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Portfolio Reflection

Throughout ENGL 2, I have developed skills that have sharpened my ability to identify and critically evaluate the assumptions embedded in arguments and the contexts that shape them. My earlier work is represented by my Critical Essay from the Reflection on College Writing (Point A). Comparing this to my last major assignment in ENGL 2, Essay 3 (Point B), I examined how my ability to recognize rhetorical situations and connect cultural assumptions to arguments has grown significantly, moving from personal reaction to critical analysis.

My Critical Essay represented where I began my college career at SJSU. In that letter to Keenan Norris, I responded emotionally, drawing entirely on personal experience rather than critical analysis. What I did not yet recognize was how I was accepting cultural assumptions without examination. I described growing up on "the blessed side," framing my family's economic position as a matter of fortune rather than structural advantage — without asking how some California communities have access to stable income and employment while others do not. I also responded to Norris, including the Biden student loan forgiveness announcement, "without including politics." However, I simply treated his narrative as straightforward truth-telling, without the contextual knowledge to recognize it as a deliberate rhetorical choice. Framing his narrative around that political moment — where the federal government was debating who would bear the cost of higher education — was a purposeful rhetorical choice aimed at a specific

audience. I can now analyze his argument and recognize that readers like myself — those navigating the financial pressures of higher education — were likely his intended audience.

My growth became more visible in Essay 1. For the first time, I applied my knowledge of rhetorical situation and cultural assumptions as analytical tools. I identified the audience as young adults who felt uncertain about their future career path and were seeking direction at the start of a new year. I also named the cultural beliefs embedded in the article's argument, writing that "this modern Western cultural belief that careers should reflect one's identity alters how people think about work, fulfillment, and achievement," and that the article's logic "originates from the Western cultural assumption that disciplined effort allows individuals to control their own destiny." This was the first essay where I shifted from reading an argument to deconstructing its specific audience, purpose, and context — from simply agreeing with it to analyzing what makes it persuasive.

In Essay 3, I applied this skill at a deeper level — and with greater independence — building my own argument by challenging the dominant cultural assumption about mental illness. My annotated bibliography served as a foundation for this work, requiring me to first evaluate the assumptions and contexts embedded in each peer-reviewed source before I could use them to build an argument. I identified the central assumption directly, writing that "for decades, the primary American response to mental illness was to place responsibility on the individual, labeling it as a lack of willpower, faith, or personal strength." Using inductive reasoning, I began with Obama's eulogy as an entry point and connected it to the research questions that guided my inquiry into systemic mental health failures. By evaluating peer-reviewed research from Crockett et al., Mahmood et al., and Buechner et al., I was able to challenge the assumption with evidence, arguing that "the failure to reach out is not a character flaw — it is a symptom of the disorder

itself." I also analyzed the rhetorical context of Obama's 2015 eulogy, recognizing that its purpose was not only to grieve but to name a national pattern of silence — much in the same way Norris's narrative was built around a politically significant moment. This time, however, I could see and name that strategy rather than simply accept it. Where I had previously taken cultural assumptions at face value, I now have the tools to identify them, find their weaknesses, and challenge them with credible peer-reviewed evidence.

In conclusion, ENGL 2 taught me that strong analytical writing begins with the ability to look past the surface of an argument and into the assumptions and rhetorical situation that give it life. From my personal response to Norris's essay — where I absorbed and simply replied with my own experiences — to my research-driven challenge of America's cultural assumptions surrounding mental illness, I have grown from a reader to an evaluator. This skill — identifying and evaluating the assumptions in and contexts of arguments — is one I will continue to use beyond the English classroom.

Works Cited

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